

The Noble Supreme and Sublime Meditative Absorption

Ārya-Samādhi-Agra-Uttama · Toh 137 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ཏིང་ངེ་འཛིན་མཆོག་དམ་པ་

Toh 137 in the Kangyur is a Buddhist sūtra known in English as "The Noble Supreme and Sublime Meditative Absorption," in Sanskrit as the Ārya-Samādhi-Agra-Uttama, and in Tibetan as the Phags pa ting nge 'dzin mchog dam pa. It belongs to the general class of Mahāyāna sūtras and centers on the theme of meditative absorption, presenting the Buddha entering into a profound samādhi known as the Samādhi of Light Rays before a vast assembly gathered at Rājagṛha, including thirty thousand monks, thousands of great bodhisattvas, and numerous classes of celestial and worldly beings. The text opens in the classic sūtra style, establishing the setting and retinue before turning to the teaching that unfolds from the Buddha's silent entry into meditation. It is preserved as a single fascicle within the Kangyur.

In the language of India: Ārya-Samādhi-Agra-Uttama. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Supreme and Sublime Meditative Absorption. One fascicle.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagṛha together with a great Saṅgha of thirty thousand monks, with approximately five thousand great bodhisattvas (bodhisattvas), with the eight classes of beings including gods and nāgas, and with a vast retinue of gods, humans, and others. Beyond these, the four protectors of the four directions, along with the four classes of beings including rākṣasas and hungry ghosts, had also gathered in that assembly.

At that time the Blessed One entered into the meditative absorption of the Samādhi of Light Rays and sat in silence, saying nothing. The great multitude of the retinue fell into doubt.

Then the bodhisattva Mañjuśrī, the youthful prince of the Dharma, rose from his seat, circumambulated the Buddha three times, and praised him with these verses:

Excellent! O lord of Dharma,
you rest in serene meditative absorption.
All the many circles of your retinue
have fallen into doubt.

Excellent! O light of sun and moon,
you speak no word, you give no sign.

Excellent! O treasury of precious jewels,
you bestow no gift upon the destitute.

Excellent! O king among men,
please arise from your meditative absorption.

Excellent! O king of nāgas,
please let fall a rain of nectar.

Excellent! O supreme among gods,
please quickly teach the Dharma.

Excellent! For the sake of sentient beings,
please teach the meaning of the single vehicle.

Then the Blessed One arose from that meditative absorption and declared to the great assembly: "I have abundant precious, unsurpassed wisdom that will bring you benefit and happiness and free you from poverty. Therefore, without doubt, ask whatever you wish."

Thereupon Ānanda rose from his seat and addressed the Blessed One thus: "Blessed One, being one of great learning, I wish to swiftly attain unsurpassed awakening. Yet as I have heard it said in the sūtras, one who is greatly learned and possessed of sharp wisdom finds awakening exceedingly difficult to attain — it is said to involve eight obstacles. How then shall I attain unsurpassed awakening?"

The Blessed One spoke to Ānanda: "Ānanda, the mind of one who is greatly learned is of two kinds. What are they? A mind abiding in meditative absorption, and a mind that is confused and distracted. When the mind abides in meditative absorption, even great learning does no harm. When the mind abides in confusion, even great learning brings no benefit. Whoever is thoroughly endowed with meditative absorption and wisdom will swiftly attain unsurpassed awakening."

Ānanda asked: "Blessed One, why is it that among all the sūtras, meditative absorption and wisdom are praised as supreme and sublime?"

The Blessed One replied to Ānanda: "Ānanda, one who is endowed with meditative absorption and wisdom is, for example, like the lion, which is supreme among wild beasts; like the sun, which is supreme among all sources

of light; like Mount Meru (Sumeru), which is supreme among mountains. And why is this? Because the force of one who is endowed with meditative absorption and wisdom is itself supreme and sublime."

The Blessed One then said to Ānanda: "Ānanda, suppose one person were to build a temple made of sandalwood filling an entire great trichiliocosm, and another person were to build a temple made of seven kinds of precious jewels also filling an entire great trichiliocosm. Would the merit of these two persons be equal?"

Ānanda replied:

"Between those two persons, the merit of the one who builds with the seven kinds of precious jewels is supreme."

The Buddha then declared to Ānanda: "Furthermore, suppose one person were to build a temple made of ordinary gold filling an entire great trichiliocosm, and another person were to build a temple made of refined gold also filling an entire great trichiliocosm. Would the merit of those two be equal?"

Ānanda replied: "The merit of the one who builds with refined gold is far greater."

The Buddha then declared to Ānanda: "Suppose one person were to fashion images from sandalwood and other fragrant woods filling an entire great trichiliocosm, and make offerings and prostrations before them, while another person were to fashion images from refined gold and the seven kinds of precious jewels filling an entire great trichiliocosm, and make offerings and prostrations before them — would there be any difference in the merit of those two persons?"

Ānanda replied: "The merit of the one who fashions images from the seven kinds of precious jewels and refined gold is greater."

The Buddha then declared to Ānanda: "Suppose one person were to arouse the mind of great generosity and give away treasures of the seven kinds of precious jewels, together with spouse and children, while another person were to give away their most precious limbs — their head, their eyes, their body — together with treasures of rare and hard-to-find precious jewels of all seven kinds. What difference would there be in the merit of those two persons?"

Ānanda replied: "The merit of giving away the seven kinds of precious jewels together with body, spouse, and children is greater."

The Buddha then declared to Ānanda: "Suppose one person were to spread throughout the world the twelve collections of sūtras for all the beings of an entire great trichiliocosm, causing them to read and recite those teachings, while another person were to cause all the beings of an entire great trichiliocosm to recite those same teachings according to the letter, and also to reveal their meaning and bring about understanding of it — which of those two persons would accumulate the greater merit?"

Ānanda replied: "The merit of reciting according to the letter and also arriving at understanding is greater."

The Buddha then declared to Ānanda: "Suppose one person were to know the twelve collections of sūtras by heart for recitation without obstruction, yet without knowing their profound meaning, while still upholding volumes of those sūtras filling an entire great trichiliocosm, and another person were to know the twelve collections of sūtras fully by heart for recitation, and also to realize their profound meaning, while likewise upholding volumes of those sūtras filling an entire great trichiliocosm — which of those two persons' merit would be supreme?"

Ānanda replied: "The merit of the one who has recited and also realized the meaning, and who furthermore teaches and expounds it to others — that merit is supreme."

The Buddha then declared to Ānanda: "Suppose one person were to comment on and expound the twelve collections of sūtras, yet were not to practice generosity, moral discipline, patience, loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity, while another person were to comment on and expound the twelve collections of sūtras and also to practice generosity, moral discipline, patience, loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity extensively, regarding all sentient beings with a mind of evenness as though they were an only child — which of those two persons' merit would be greater?"

Ānanda replied: "The merit of the one who practices loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity, moral discipline, and patience, and who gives generously to sentient beings — that merit is great and abundant."

The Blessed One then declared to Ānanda:

"If a person were able to comment on and expound the twelve collections of sūtras and also to expound and spread abroad in the world the seventy-five treatises — and if another person were able to comment on and expound

those same twelve collections of sūtras, and also to know the seventy-five treatises, including the treatise on inference, the treatise on certainty, the treatise on the five aggregates, the treatise on the twelve links of dependent origination, the treatise on the eighteen elements, the treatise on great emptiness, the treatise on the sun and moon, the treatise on the sun, moon, and clouds, the treatise on the ornament of sūtras, the treatise on the ultimate itself, the treatise on the vajra essence, the treatise on omniscience, the treatise on the three gateways of liberation, and so forth — all seventy-five treatises; and were also to practice generosity, moral discipline, patience, loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity; and with a mind that makes no distinction between those of broken moral discipline and those who guard it, that is even like space, that sees no fault in any sentient being, and that regards sentient beings as though they were an only child — even treating enemies with evenness like the sky — and if yet another person were to cast no aspersions on the twelve collections of sūtras that have spread in all directions: which of these two persons' merit would be greater?"

Ānanda replied: "If one casts no aspersions on the twelve collections of sūtras that have spread in all directions, that person's merit is beyond measure, beyond counting — it is inconceivable."

The Blessed One then declared to Ānanda: "Moreover, even though the sum of all the merit mentioned above might be sufficient to fill the world-systems of an entire great trichilocosm, if a person were also able to recite and expound the twelve collections of sūtras and all seventy-five treatises, and were also to practice moral discipline, patience, loving-kindness, and the rest, and also to give generously, and were the foremost among the greatly learned, and were to teach the meaning that all phenomena are empty and at peace — and were even to cause listeners to attain the five superknowledges — yet for all that benefit and welfare thus provided, such a person would not be capable of entering into meditative absorption even for a single day or a single night. Why? Because a greatly learned person has a mind of pride as vast as a mountain or an ocean. One who has such great pride will endure suffering in the lower realms for countless eons. And even when released from those hells, such a one would be reborn as a feathered bird — so what good is great learning?

One who possesses the meditative absorption of dhyāna is capable of purifying the heavy karmic actions of the misconduct of the cycle of birth and death. Great learning is like grass; meditative absorption is like fire. Great

learning is like iron; the meditative absorption of dhyāna is like gold. Great learning is like incense; the meditative absorption of dhyāna is like the incense tree itself. Great learning is like a river; the meditative absorption of dhyāna is like the ocean. Were I to speak of the merit and qualities of the meditative absorption of dhyāna, there would be no end to it — it would not be exhausted even in an eon.

The Blessed One then declared to Ānanda: "I recall directly from times past that when I was a greatly learned person, Mañjuśrī and I fell into dispute over existence and non-existence: Mañjuśrī asserted existence, while I asserted non-existence. We fell into dispute over the truth of these two positions — existence and non-existence — and could reach no resolution."

In the end, at death, that person was reborn in a lower realm, and for countless eons was made to eat iron pellets. Released at last from that hell, he encountered the buddha Kāśyapa, and Kāśyapa explained the two truths of existence and non-existence in these words: "The intrinsic nature of all phenomena is definitively one and without interruption. Your speaking of existence and non-existence is not how the matter truly stands. Why is that? Because all phenomena are at peace through emptiness. These two truths — existence and non-existence — are neither existent nor non-existent. What you know amounts only to knowing the literal meaning of words; you do not know the profound meaning. With regard to a matter such as this, you are like one who is blind or deaf — how could you know and realize a profound meaning such as this?"

Upon hearing these words, he went to a solitary mountain, turned his mind inward upon itself, and entered into the meditative absorption of dhyāna. When seven days had passed, he came to realize and penetrate the tranquil meditative absorption of dhyāna, the three kinds of meditative absorption, the three kinds of gnosis, great emptiness, ultimate emptiness, and the emptiness of emptiness. He realized that all phenomena are at peace through emptiness — that there is nothing whatsoever. Why? Because all phenomena are empty by their very essential nature.

Therefore one should know that the cultivation of dhyāna is supremely excellent. Whoever cultivates the meditative absorption of dhyāna for a single day, a single night, or up to seven days and nights — even the heaviest of misdeeds accumulated over countless eons will be swiftly stilled and purified. Moreover, the heaviest misdeeds will be cleansed as well. What are these?

Killing one's father or mother, killing an arhat, destroying a stūpa or temple, burning the Saṅgha's dwelling places with fire — these are the four root downfalls, the eight root downfalls, the five grave offenses, the six naturally grave offenses, slandering the sūtras of the extensive teachings, speaking of the faults and failings of one's opponents and showing them no respect, and being excessively arrogant wherever one is born — even these, which are naturally grave misdeeds, will be spontaneously stilled and cleansed through the cultivation of the meditative absorption of dhyāna. And this cleansing comes through the power of the meditative absorption of dhyāna itself — it is not cleansed by anything external.

If, through a mere seven days of practice, one thus obtains immeasurable qualities and merit, what need is there even to speak of dwelling in solitude throughout an entire lifetime — seated at a mountain hermitage or at the foot of a tree — applying one's mind to clearing away conceptual thought, to engagement, and to relinquishment? Why is that? The mind is like a cascading stream: it does not rest even for a single instant. The mind is like a monkey: let go of one thing and it grasps another. In brief, it is through the power of meditative absorption that the mind becomes unmoving. If the mind moves, mistaken perceptions arise with regard to all phenomena. But if one rests in meditative absorption, one perceives and realizes arising, abiding, and ceasing in the world, and understands that all phenomena are at peace through emptiness — impermanent, subject to change and transition, empty and selfless, like an illusion, like an emanation, like lightning, like the wind, like a gandharva city, like a water bubble, like a mirage, like an echo, like the track of a bird across the sky.

As for existence in the world — mountains, forests, rivers, cascades, lakes, swamps, oceans, and all bodies of water whatsoever — when the great eon of fire arrives, all will burn up and be exhausted. Yet save for the four dhyānas and the four formless meditative absorptions, everything will be consumed. Knowing all phenomena as emptiness, one should understand that the power of dhyāna is utterly inconceivable.

When the mind rests in meditative absorption, one will behold the suns, moons, stars, waterfalls, rivers, oceans, mountains, forests, and valleys of the great trichiliocosm of the ten directions — all appearing as though placed in the palm of one's hand, like a myrobalan fruit.

When one rests in the meditative absorption of dhyāna, through miraculous power one can travel to world-systems in the ten directions as numerous as the grains of sand in the Ganges River, and through miraculous power one can emanate wind, fire, earth, water, sun, moon, stars, planets, mountains, forests, rivers, trees, divine palaces, and nāga palaces throughout the world-systems of the ten directions. Therefore, one should know that the power of dhyāna is utterly inconceivable. Through the force of the meditative absorption of dhyāna, one can even emanate the entire great trichiliocosm of the world-systems of the ten directions.

The noble Maudgalyāyana, entering meditative absorption, was able through that absorption to emanate myriad forms, and through absorption he could set this very great earth spinning like a potter's wheel. One should know that mere learning cannot accomplish this.

The Blessed One said to Ānanda, "Ānanda, shake the great earth!" Ānanda replied, "I lack the meditative absorption of dhyāna, and so I have no means by which to move it." The Blessed One then declared to Ānanda: "A renunciant who cultivates the meditative absorption of dhyāna, even without attaining the four fruits, surpasses one who has mere learning by many hundreds of thousands of tens of thousands."

At that time, some five hundred monks dwelling in the grove of Amra had all become proud of their great learning. Hearing the Blessed One proclaim to Ānanda that Maudgalyāyana's miraculous power and meditative absorption were supreme, they went to where the Buddha was, bowed their heads at the feet of the Blessed One, and addressed the Buddha with these words: "Blessed One, we have trained in great learning and have thoroughly mastered the twelve branches of scripture. The kings of sixteen great realms revere and honor us as though we were buddhas. Why, then, does the Blessed One say that those with mere learning will never attain unsurpassed awakening?" Having said this, the five hundred monks together at the same moment addressed the Blessed One: "We are giving up mere learning and shall train in the meditative absorption of dhyāna."

The Blessed One declared to the monks: "Monks, do not say that you are giving up great learning and entering the meditative absorption of dhyāna. As I see it, your wisdom is like a gnat wishing to eclipse the sun and moon with its wings, like a blind man wishing to climb Mount Meru, like one wishing to cross the ocean without a boat, like a bird with broken wings wishing to soar through

the sky — you, too, are just like that." At these words, the monks were gripped by a fear and terror as though facing death itself.

Then the Blessed One declared to the monks: "Monks, do not be afraid or terrified — place your minds in meditative absorption." The monks replied: "We have no power of dhyāna — how could we enter absorption?" The Blessed One declared: "I have excellent medicine that will enable you to attain meditative absorption." The monks then requested, "Blessed One, please teach it to us. We shall practice accordingly." The Blessed One declared: "What is called excellent medicine is this: conceptual thought and —"

discernment, engagement, and relinquishment. The monks asked: "What are conceptual thought, discernment, engagement, and relinquishment? Since we do not understand them, may the Blessed One please teach us." Then the Buddha declared as follows: "The first arising of mind is called conceptual thought. The arising of a second moment of mind is called discernment. The arising of a third moment of mind is called engagement. The arising of a fourth moment of mind is called relinquishment. Furthermore, it is also like this: the first dhyāna is called conceptual thought, the second dhyāna is called discernment, the third dhyāna is called engagement, and the fourth dhyāna is called relinquishment. Furthermore, it is also like this: meditative concentration means the close placement of mindfulness on the body, the close placement of mindfulness on the mind, the close placement of mindfulness on phenomena, and the close placement of mindfulness on feelings — and likewise the four higher knowledges, the four thorough relinquishments of all phenomena, the four bases of miraculous power, the Four Noble Truths, the four samādhis, the four signlessnesses, and the four awakenings. If, monks, you have not clearly understood even the first dhyāna, what need is there to speak of the four dhyānas and all phenomena? Monks, you must enter into the meditative absorption of dhyāna by means of many skillful methods.

If one meditates on impurity, one perceives the body as having four great elements — skin, bones, joints, and a flow of pus and blood — and the body as a vessel with nine openings: when water is poured into it, it leaks out; and so one sees the impure things of the body — excrement and urine, large and small — flowing out like leaking, utterly repulsive filth. From within that absorption one also sees the object in various aspects: moving and still, appearing bluish, appearing yellowish, appearing whitish, and appearing blackish — seeing these various distinct forms. When, with an undistracted

mind, one sees such objects, one should turn back. The meditation on white bones and the counting of in-breaths and out-breaths is similar to this as well.

If a monk has transgressed the four root precepts of moral discipline, or a nun has transgressed the eight root precepts, or a laywoman has transgressed the five root precepts, or a novice has transgressed the ten precepts, or a trainee nun has transgressed the six weighty rules, or one has stolen the common property of the Buddha, the Dharma, or the Saṅgha, or has stolen the property of one's preceptor, ācārya, teacher, one's parents, or the Saṅgha, or is a person who has disparaged the widely-spread sūtras — when such a person enters into the meditative absorption of dhyāna, they will perceive: their own body and breath as like a black wind, their blood as like a blazing fire, their bones as like mountains and cliffs, their sinews as like trees, and the five inner organs as like snakes or frogs; they will see themselves running with a great fire in their hands through a mighty gale, then rising up with a great mountain on their head only to be crushed down again, then from their mouth a lion coming forth, from their eyes fire flames emerging, from their nose a great serpent coming out, from their ears leaping wolves coming forth, and their excrement and urine, large and small, falling like water and appearing vast as an ocean. And if they see all the buddhas of the ten directions displaying many miraculous feats, when they see such signs they should arise from meditative absorption, go to a forest grove or a mountain hermitage, recite the widely-spread sūtras, and perform full confession.

In this way, one should perform full confession of past non-virtuous misdeeds for between seven days and seven times seven days — that is, seven, or twice seven, or three times seven, or four times seven, or five times seven, or six times seven, or up to seven times seven days."

Having thus purified non-virtuous deeds through full confession, one should then practice meditative concentration. For one whose misdeeds are slight, one's own body will appear in meditative absorption like a mountain of lapis lazuli.

For one who has not transgressed the four root precepts and has not violated anything up to the five weighty offenses against the natural moral law, when entering meditative absorption one will see the buddhas of the ten directions simultaneously teaching the Dharma — teaching either the Four Noble Truths, or the four right abandonments, or the four bases of miraculous power, or suffering, or patient forbearance, or the supreme worldly Dharma beginning

with the crown of existence, or the seven branches of awakening, or the four meditative concentrations, or the Dharma of the eight noble persons, or the four emptinesses, or the three samādhis, or the eight liberations. Upon seeing these things in absorption, and upon seeing darkness or light arising in meditative absorption, one should arise from that absorption and give rise to a mind of intense joy. So declared the Blessed One.

The monks then went to the forest grove outside, and by practicing the meditative absorption of dhyāna for seven days, they all attained arhatship. They then came into the presence of the Blessed One and addressed the Buddha thus: "Blessed One, we have, just as the Buddha taught, been liberated from saṃsāra and attained the unsurpassed fruit."

The Blessed One declared: "Having attained this, the time has come to display miraculous feats."

At that, the five hundred monks rose up into the space above and displayed eighteen kinds of miraculous feats — lying down, sitting, walking, and standing in mid-air, and emanating fire and water from their bodies and so forth. Thereupon the learned monks, by practicing meditative concentration, became equal in miraculous power to Mahāmaudgalyāyana, without any difference whatsoever.

Then Ānanda addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, for how long will this sacred Dharma endure after the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, and how many sentient beings in this degenerate age, by practicing this Dharma, will attain the four fruits of the contemplative life?"

The Blessed One spoke to Ānanda: "From now on, in the middle month of spring, I shall pass into nirvāṇa in the city of Kuśinagara. After my passing, for eighty years, many sentient beings devoted to the Dharma will arise, dwelling in charnel grounds and at the roots of trees, engaging in four contemplative practices — examining, clearing away, entering, and abandoning — and of those who practice in ten thousand ways, nine thousand will attain the four fruits of the contemplative life.

Within three hundred years, of groups of ten thousand sentient beings, those practicing in ten thousand ways will attain the four fruits of the contemplative life.

From three hundred years onward up to five hundred years, those who are my attendants will mostly practice non-virtuous Dharma. With minds of envy they

will sustain themselves through wrong livelihood. Of five hundred thousand, ten thousand will attain the fruits of the contemplative life.

From five hundred years onward up to eight hundred years, those who are my attendants will don householder's clothing, keep cattle, sheep, cats, donkeys, and horses, accumulate much grain, and till the fields themselves, eating meat and drinking alcohol, keeping and feeding male and female servants. In that time, of a million, one thousand will attain the four fruits of the contemplative life.

From eight hundred years onward up to one thousand years, those who are my attendants will train in sinful conduct, befriending kings, princes, great ministers, and householders, deceiving one another even through messengers, plowing and digging fields, hoarding much grain, gold, silver, and the seven precious substances, eating meat and drinking alcohol, keeping and feeding the four great elements of livestock, wearing layered garments like prostitutes and leading people astray, engaging in deceptive activity —

From among a million, about one hundred will attain the four fruits of the contemplative life.

From one thousand years onward down to three hundred years, great turbulence will arise, and my attendants, though they wear the robe of the Dharma on their bodies, will be like old, tattered rags hung on a wooden peg — devoid of all dignity and radiance. When householders see them, they will not pay them respect, and they will be regarded as no better than butchers. At that time the regions and territories too will be thrown into turmoil; people will become enemies to one another and kill one another, so that kings and ministers, fathers and mothers, sons and daughters will all be enemies to one another. There will be no love and no compassion in their hearts. They will be afflicted by food and drink, and those without a home, without a wife, without a son, without a daughter — the blind, the lame, the mute, the incomplete in faculties, male slaves and female slaves who have fled — will ravage the regions and territories. Those who cannot sustain their own lives will enter my Dharma, and yet householders will look upon them as they look upon hunters. It will be like a divine bull, or a wild horse, or a frenzied yak — hard to tame and going wherever they please. Teachers and students alike will be like wild and unruly men; they will conduct themselves heedlessly in attachment and desire, with no hierarchy of superior and inferior, no gradation of good and bad, and they will be like animals and livestock. They will commit many

blameworthy sins, and while they go about unafraid of the three lower destinies wherever they wander, they will consort and associate with wine sellers, butchers, hunters, and prostitutes. With their mouths they will speak sinful words, and in their minds they will harbour sinful thoughts. Or else they will align themselves with ministers and, by various means, oppress good people, steal their wealth, and use it to feed their children. Or they will carry the hunter's tools — fishing nets and the like — catch fish and other creatures, kill them with their own hands, burn them, dry them in the sun, and when they come to die they will perform no restoration ceremony but simply abandon themselves. Those engaged in the activities of the moral discipline will quarrel with one another, bearing aversion toward their superiors, their inferiors, and their companions, arousing malicious minds, and teachers and students alike will pick out one another's faults, speak words of mockery and slander — like a great mass of thorns all gathered together in one place — and in their factions and groups they will silence one another with harsh words. There will be no hierarchy of higher and lower; like wild and unruly men, they will compete to steal credit for virtuous acts, and they will be attached to gain and fame. The Dharma will no longer be known. At that time even the twelve branches of scripture will have declined, and there will be neither reading nor recitation. My disciples too will study and practise what is not the Dharma: the sciences of adversaries, classical learning, letters, games, riding, the Bon religion, eye medicine, song and dance, festivals, archery, the art of throwing, horse racing, and the like. By practising such wrongful conduct, the moment they depart this life they will fall into the lower destinies. For immeasurable eons they will experience the sufferings of the lower destinies, and upon emerging from them they will be reborn as animals, harassed by hunger and thirst and suffering, forced to go about bearing heavy loads.

Later still, those who study the qualities of meditative training will increasingly practise what is not the Dharma. They will not dwell in mountain retreats, in forests, charnel grounds, or at the roots of trees, but will constantly run to towns. Their minds will be filled with discursive thought; they will seek gain and fame, be attached to wealth and possessions and enjoyments, and know no contentment. Even if there is someone who teaches the Dharma, not even one in ten thousand throne-sitters who teach the Buddha's Dharma will truly reach the point.

They will go about with large retinues, enter the homes of householders, and teach the Dharma to laypeople — but only for the sake of gain and fame.

Accumulating many possessions, they will be like butchers. Those who do not partake of meat and alcohol will rebuke the monks, saying: "You monastics have gone forth from home into homelessness — yet you have no compassion. By practising so much that is not the Dharma, you are just like butchers." And they will revile and abuse them openly.

When those monks hear themselves rebuked in such words, they will turn on the accusers, striking them, scolding them, and shouting abuse, saying to one another: "When the Tathāgata was alive, he did not permit us to drink alcohol or eat meat — but now that the Tathāgata has passed into nirvāṇa, there is no longer any prohibition, and so we do eat meat and drink alcohol." After the departure of the laypeople, they will say to one another: "What we know comes directly from the mouth of the Buddha" — while some will speak in frivolous words, in meaningless words, in contentious words, in confused and mistaken words. It will be like a blind man who raises two fingers toward the sun and says, "The sun is small — it is wide — it is dim," or like someone of unsound mind who says, "Up in the sky I hear the sound of the Dharma being taught." Just so, many blind people will gather together.

In the world, emanations of Mañjuśrī, Mahākāśyapa, and others will appear and dwell in their midst, yet everyone will strike and revile them, drive them away, and refuse to let them stay.

As another analogy: a lion dwells on a fragrant mountain, and no beast of the field nor any predator can bear to remain in that place. But once the lion has gone and departed from that mountain, the fierce and savage beasts of prey call out to one another, come to the fragrant mountain, eat its sweet fruits, and drink from its springs. By eating and drinking in this way, they exhaust and lay waste to everything there. Even the gods dwelling on the fragrant mountain will no longer be able to protect it; poisonous plants will grow, and whoever eats them will immediately meet their end.

After I have passed into nirvāṇa, all monks will recite and read the twelve branches of scripture that I have taught — but they will place the upper portion in the middle, the middle portion at the bottom, and the lower portion at the top; the middle they will place at the bottom and at the end. They will call what has no meaning "meaningful," and what is meaningful they will call "not meaningful" — just as the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) each separately say, "My own system is the true one." At that time, even though the twelve branches of scripture will circulate in the world, they will have no splendour or

power. Some may recite or read them, yet there will not be a single person who attains the four fruits of the ascetic life. Thus my disciples will be like a king who has lost his throne, like a bird without wings. Temples and stūpas will stand empty and crumbling, with no one to restore them. Images of the Teacher's body, victory banners, and precious parasols will be like shattered armour, becoming nesting and dwelling places for owls, sparrows, pigs, dogs, sheep, and the like. The individual dwelling places of the monks will be turned into good rubbish heaps.

The Blessed One then declared to Ānanda: "I have given you only a brief account of all this." Ānanda, hearing what the Buddha had said, was overcome with tears and wept.

As Ānanda remained there, his heart distressed and weeping uncontrollably, the Blessed One declared to him: "Do not weep like this. Take this sūtra as a dhāraṇī and spread it widely throughout the world."

Then Ānanda wiped the tears from his face and addressed the Blessed One: "I shall take it up and hold it as a dhāraṇī."

Śakra (Indra, king of the gods), the gods, and

The people also spoke to Ānanda thus: "Venerable one, we too shall take it up and hold it. Whoever recites or reads this sūtra — whether on a mountain, in a grove, at the foot of a tree, at the edge of a forest, or in a charnel ground — we shall go to that place along with our retinues of gods, humans, and non-humans, and there, even if it be but a single verse or a single phrase, we shall retain it without forgetting and without losing a word."

When this sūtra was taught, approximately one thousand monks attained the four fruits of the ascetic life. Fifteen hundred nuns attained the fruit of stream-entry. Five hundred laymen became perfectly purified, and gods, humans, asuras, and the rest paid homage and departed.

The noble sūtra "Supreme and Excellent Meditative Absorption" is complete.

Translator's Notes

- The name rendered as "Ānanda" translates the Tibetan "Dga' bo," which literally means "the Joyful One" and is the standard Tibetan translation of the Sanskrit proper name Ānanda. The text identifies him as asking about learning and awakening in a manner consistent with Ānanda's traditional characterization as foremost in learning.

The phrase "eight obstacles" refers to a list of eight impediments to attaining awakening for those of great learning. The text alludes to this as a known teaching from the sūtras without

enumerating the eight here; this is not a textual gap but an intentional reference to an established teaching.

The translation breaks off at "Ānanda replied:" because the Tibetan passage ends mid-sentence at that point, with Ānanda's answer not included in the provided text.

- The phrase rendered "twelve collections of sūtras" translates གཞི་བཅུ་གཉིས་ཀྱི་ཡི་གེ་ཆུང་ཆུང་།, which refers to the twelvefold division of the Buddhist canon by literary genre (the twelve aṅgas), not twelve individual sūtra texts. This is the standard Indic classification of canonical literature.
- The list of "seventy-five treatises" (Tib. bstan bcos u ta bcwa lnga) is a specific canonical enumeration whose Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain; the Tibetan transliteration is irregular and the underlying term has not been conclusively identified in extant Sanskrit sources.

The individual treatise titles in the list (treatise on inference, on certainty, on the sun and moon, on the vajra essence, etc.) correspond to identifiable Indian scholastic categories in some cases, but several titles in this list are unusual or may reflect titles specific to this sūtra's provenance; no attempt has been made to impose identifications not warranted by the text.

The phrase rendered "feathered bird" (Tib. 'dab chags kyi bya) literally means "a bird with wings" — the point being rebirth as an ordinary animal, with the specific image of a bird emphasizing the contrast with the high status the learned person once held.

- The phrase rendered "the three kinds of meditative absorption" and "the three kinds of gnosis" translates bare enumerations without further specification in this passage; the text lists them as part of a series of attainments reached after seven days. The specific referents of "three absorptions" and "three wisdoms" are not spelled out here and may depend on a broader commentarial context not present in this excerpt.

The phrase "the six naturally grave offenses" renders rang bzhin gyi lci ba drug, a Vinaya category; the exact list varies by tradition and is not enumerated in the text itself.

The simile of the gandharva city renders dri za'i grong khyer, literally "city of scent-eaters," the standard Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit gandharvanagara, a proverbial mirage-city.

- The text breaks off mid-sentence with "conceptual thought and —" as this is where the supplied passage ends; the list that follows will appear in the next segment.

The epithet "Ānanda" renders Tibetan "Dga' bo," literally "the Joyful One," which is a standard Tibetan rendering of the Sanskrit name Ānanda. This is consistent throughout.

"Myrobalan fruit" renders skyu ru ra, the Tibetan name for āmalaka or harītakī, a small round fruit proverbially used to illustrate something held clearly in the palm of one's hand.

"The twelve branches of scripture" refers to the twelve-fold scriptural classification standard in Indian Buddhist tradition (the twelve aṅgas).

- The fourfold scheme of "conceptual thought, discernment, engagement, and relinquishment" applied both to moments of mind and to the four dhyānas is an unusual early Abhidharmic or proto-Abhidharmic formulation not standard in the Pāli or mainstream Sanskrit Abhidharma; it likely reflects an apocryphal or Central Asian transmission. The term rendered "discernment" here (Tibetan bsal ba, literally "clearing" or "removal") is used in a technical enumerative sense that does not map cleanly onto any single standard Sanskrit term — it may represent vicāra in the dhyāna context, though applied here across a broader schema.

The passage on visions arising during meditation for those who have broken precepts is a striking practical warning text. "Five inner organs" renders nang grol lnga, literally "five inner releases" — this almost certainly refers to the five visceral organs (heart, lungs, liver, spleen, kidneys), a reading supported by the surrounding anatomical context.

- The phrase rendered "the four right abandonments" translates the Sanskrit catvāri samyakprahāṇāni; "the four bases of miraculous power" translates catvāri ṛddhipādāḥ; "the four emptinesses" here likely refers to a specific enumeration such as the four śūnyatās taught in Āgama literature rather than the standard Mahāyāna set; "the three samādhis" refers to the three gateways to liberation — emptiness, signlessness, and wishlessness; "the eight liberations" translates aṣṭau vimokṣāḥ. The "eight noble persons" refers to the eight individuals on or at the four pairs of the path to arhatship. The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text provided, so the translation likewise ends there.
- The phrase rendered "throne-sitters" refers to those who mount a Dharma throne to teach publicly; the Tibetan idiom here implies that out of ten thousand such preachers, not even one will genuinely convey the Buddha's teaching. The exact force is slightly compressed in the original and the rendering reflects the most natural doctrinal reading.

The list "the twelve branches of scripture" refers to the dvādaśāṅga, the canonical twelve-fold classification of the Buddha's teaching, a standard enumeration in Mahāyāna sources.

- The term rendered "twelve branches of scripture" refers to the traditional twelve-fold classification of the Buddha's teaching by literary form, a standard doctrinal enumeration. The passage's point is that monks will scramble their order, rendering the canon unintelligible.

The name "Mahākāśyapa" appears here in the Tibetan as མཁའ་ཀུན་ལུ་པུ་ཤེས་པ་, literally "the Great Kāśyapa," which is a standard Tibetan rendering of Mahākāśyapa, the senior disciple of the Buddha. It is paired with Mañjuśrī, which is unusual given Mañjuśrī's status as a bodhisattva and Mahākāśyapa's as an arhat, but the text plainly presents both as appearing in the world as emanations to benefit beings during the decline of the Dharma.

- The phrase rendered "four fruits of the ascetic life" translates a standard list: stream-entry, once-returning, non-returning, and arhatship — the four śrāmaṇya-phala. The title reconstructed at the colophon, "Supreme and Excellent Meditative Absorption," renders the Tibetan literally; the Sanskrit title is likely Paramādya-samādhi or similar, but no Sanskrit witness is cited in the passage itself.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.